

No more struggles in charging your mobile phone while on the go... sounds interesting. We met some guys, who are bringing this task to practical reach.

Revolution For Charge... and Charge!

Jiten Gandhi

Nash David

Actions speak louder than words, or so they say—precisely what the trio from our very own IIT Bombay believes. We all know of the implications of energy resources getting exhausted and the resultant rise in electricity costs. Most of us, wish we had better ways to stay live and kicking with our gadgets, without the need to constantly plug them into the AC mains sockets. There's now reason to smile, there's hope coming our way.

Making A Difference

We met Ankit Mehta (25), Ashish Bhat (24) and Rahul Singh (24), who have come together to form a start up focussing on energy solutions for your gadgets. "Our aim is to be a company that gives the consumer the freedom of walls-free charging", according to Mehta, Managing Director of ideaForge, who heads the firm's attempt to provide a typical user like you, the freedom to charge your mobile phone, anytime, anywhere—be it in office, sitting idle in a park or even while travelling on your bike.

The Company

As we caught up with the team incubated at the Kanwal Rekhi School of Information Technology in the IIT Bombay campus, Mehta shed light on the way the team met, came together, got organised and managed the design and launch of their products. It all started somewhere in 2004, in IIT Bombay, where they casually interacted among themselves. The initial plan to work on energy solu-

tions, was conceived a couple of years later, in 2006. As the drive to innovate got the better of them, they decided to get their acts together and in the summer of 2007, formed ideaForge in its current form.

Finances came in the form of Technopreneur Promotion Programme (TePP), a government body that promotes innovative technology startups. Other than that, there were personal funds in addition to an angel investor.

Their Products

ideaForge has developed three useful products for the Indian market. A USB-powered mobile charger, a hand-cranking or mechanical phone charger and a two-wheeler solution for mobile phone charging. They have profiled their market into two segments—urban and rural. As per their study, the penetration of Nokia, Sony Ericsson and Motorola is higher in the urban areas, while that of LG and Samsung is higher in the rural areas. Accordingly, they have packaged their chargers with adapters for phones depending on the market they will be shipped to. With the adapters that they provide in their packaging, you are able to charge 90 per cent of mobile phones commercially available in the market, without any additional accessories. In the event that your phone's adapter is not available, they are open to helping you out in that area too.

We checked out their USB chargers back in our office for the whole month while we were working on this article, and it worked really well. While in office, all you need to do is plug in the phone to the USB charger with the other end plugged in to the USB port of your laptop or



Bike charger in use. Now get your phone charged even while travelling